



How Earth got its oxygen

Scientists have revealed new clues into how Earth got its oxygen by analyzing ancient rocks. <http://digit.in/nov20-15>



Antartica to continue melting

Ice loss in Antartica is expected to continue, despite attempts to control climate change. <http://digit.in/nov20-16>



NAZCA LINES

Mysterious geoglyphs in Peru

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pread out over an area of about 450 square kilometers in the Nazca Desert of southern Peru, are a

cluster of colossal motifs scratched into the soil, known as geoglyphs. The biggest of these glyphs measures 900 feet across. The lines can be even longer, with the longest one stretching for 20 kilometers. They were created over a 1,000 years between 500 BCE and 500 CE. Many of the lines are biomorphs, including a whale, a monkey, a hummingbird, a condor, an iguana, a spider, a heron, a

parrot and a dog. The hummingbird measuring 93 meters across and the condor, spreading over 134 meters, are particularly large. Apart from the biomorphs, there are many geometrical designs, including trapezoids, rectangles, triangles and spirals. The lines are considered to be discovered by the Peruvian archaeologist Majia Xesspe 1927, although the spanish conquistador Pedro Cieza de León described them as trail markers in 1553. Last month, a design of a cat was discovered on one of the hills in the area, which was itself being modified as a suitable viewing platform for many of the lines in the area.

Most of the designs are only apparent when viewed from the air, looking like random scribbles from the ground. As such, the forms and shapes can only be appreciated from the air. What makes them so inter-

esting to scientists, and not just lay people, is the mystery of their function. Typically, when archaeologists unearth something that they do not understand, they just ascribe some sort of religious or spiritual function and call it a day. However, the function of the Nazca lines, as well as their creation remains a mystery, making them a subject of many fringe theories.

FUNCTION OF THE LINES

Since the lines can only be perceived from the air, a religious significance is still one of the most popular theories. Some scientists believe that the lines were created so that the gods can appreciate them from their vantage point in the skies. Other scientists believe that they are markings on the ground that indicate the physical track to be taken during spiritual